

KF Introduction to NHG

Chapter 3: *The Tyranny of the Should*¹

Let's return to Nancy's story and learn a little more about the history of Karis Fellowships, which may help you trust in the value of your own efforts toward recovering your real self.

In 1977, Nancy returned to the United States from the mission field deeply troubled about her inability to sincerely love herself and others. Through a series of astonishing miracles, God led her to a Christian college in southern California where she met a man who did not conform to the conventions of her Christian upbringing. He taught her that the only productive goal for a Christian is to live consistently without fear and in agape love. The Apostle Paul wrote about this love in a letter to the Corinthian church, and believe me, the Corinthians were just as confused about love as our culture is today. The love that Paul described has nothing to do with our emotions and everything to do with our choices. He said that without this love our work is nothing, we accomplish nothing, and, even more pitiful, we are nothing. Nancy felt deeply convicted about the need to change the direction of her Christian life, and with God's help, she began that very difficult work. She withdrew from church activities and dedicated the next two decades of her life to learning to love.

Nancy became increasingly aware that most of her choices were motivated by a kind of self-created legal system full of claims, shoulds, and taboos. This personal law dictated what she should do, think, and feel, and imposed taboos that prescribed what she shouldn't do, think, and feel. Although her law provided some sort of compass by which she navigated her life, it also stifled every real thought, emotion, desire, and delight, and generated a lot of self-hate. She lacked the inner peace that supports exploration and personal development; all her energy was devoted to obeying her loveless law and managing her anxiety. Her commitment to this law of shoulds and taboos was the source of her inflexibility, impatience, and unloving reactions. She was more committed to adhering to her own law than to following the Lord of love.

Most students find these chapters about shoulds and claims very troubling. They fear that if they were to walk away from their beliefs about how they and others should act, they would be overrun by chronic confusion and insecurity. Perhaps you are asking yourself, "If I give up my shoulds and claims, how will I motivate myself or others?" Letting go of our shoulds and claims is part of losing our lives for Christ's sake, and losing our lives isn't easy. It is scary work and requires courage, dedication, and endurance.

God is eager to help us move away from law and learn to live in love. Love becomes the great motivation for those who have been rescued from law. In Karis Fellowships, we help each other learn how to love as the Bible teaches us. We stir each other up to love and good works. What is the greatest commandment? It is to love the Lord your God with all your heart, soul, mind, and strength, and the next is just like it: to love your neighbor as yourself. Jesus teaches us that loving God, loving others, and loving our real self are synonymous. As God's children, love is not only our greatest motivation – it is our greatest achievement. Now let's finish Nancy's story. Soon after arriving at college, Nancy met her husband, Chuck, and together they began the work of learning to apply real love in their lives. After over forty years of marriage and through many difficulties and joys, they are still exploring the potential of that great adventure, an adventure that continues to develop their real self and build their trust in the Person of God.

When you download your next reading guide, print off the KF document **Are You in Love or Pride?** Refer to it regularly as you begin to examine your life and your choices in the light of real love.

¹ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).